



IIT ROORKEE



NPTEL ONLINE
CERTIFICATION COURSE

Public Speaking

LECTURE 42: Conference Presentations Part I

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Categories of Conference

INFORMATIVE: Descriptive; To share theoretical or factual information

DISCURSIVE: To debate the strengths and limitations of an idea; To argue for or against a motion

DEMONSTRATIVE: To showcase your understanding of a concept, or to teach/train practically

Conference: Types

1. **Academic Conference:** An academic conference (also called **academic congress** or **research conference**) refers to meetings organized by associations to present and discuss the findings of ongoing academic researches (either narrow & discipline-specific or interdisciplinary).

Attending academic conferences assumes a **pivotal significance in one's academic career**, as they:

- ☐ Offer intellectual exposure to the researchers by providing them with a platform to present their ideas to experts for their feedback
- ☐ Apprise of new discoveries in the discipline
- ☐ The questions posed at the researchers open new insights for them about the challenges in their project
- ☐ Help the participants to improve upon their presentation skills
- ☐ Offer opportunities to forge valuable connections with knowledgeable experts on the topic
- ☐ Disseminate the results of your research for the benefit of the society

Conference: Types (Contd.)

- 2. Business Conference:** These are professional gatherings which bring together business leaders, economists, techies from across the globe to discuss the trends, challenges and opportunities pertaining to their industry.

Participating in business conferences enables the entrepreneurs to:

Learn innovative business skills and marketing techniques

Showcase business expertise among clients

Expand network, stimulate new ideas, create valuable contacts

Launch new services, ideas and products, or advertise the existing ones

Assess the strengths and weaknesses of the competing market rivals

Conference: Types (Contd.)

3. Author's Conference:

Also called writers' conference

A conference of literary professionals attended by authors, editors, publishers and members of literary fraternity

Purpose – To discuss and review written works



4. Judicial Settlement Conference:

An informal meeting between conflicting parties of a lawsuit in the presence of a judicial officer to discuss, negotiate and resolve issues

5. Press Conference:

A media event to officially broadcast a message/news out to the general public

Conference: Types (Contd.)

6. Global Conference:

International forum to call on governments, business institutions, and global stakeholders to formulate plans and proposals towards achieving shared global goals.

Examples include – United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development, United Nations Climate Change Conference.



7. Peace Conference:

International meet between representative diplomats of warring nations to end antagonism and to negotiate a peace treaty.

8. Unconference:

Participation-oriented conference in a loosely structured, informal format, unlike the conventional structured conferences.



Conference: Types (Contd.)

9. Virtual Conference:

Online conference which enables remotely located participants to participate in live onsite discussions and events with the help of Internet and other technological aids



Pros

- Overcomes geographical barriers
- Larger outreach
- Cost-effective
- Time-efficient

Cons

- Unequal access due to '*digital divide*'
- Over-reliance on technology

Types of Speakers at Conference

Plenary Speaker

- The speaker is often from within the organization
 - Unlike the keynote session, it is attended by all of the conference attendees
- Thus, the topic of the talk is broader in scope.

Keynote Speaker

- An invited talk by an outsider expert
- Creates awareness about the underlying theme of the event
- To set the tone, and also to summarize the core essence of the event

EMCEE

- Means 'Master of Ceremonies' - Hosts the event
- Introduces the theme of the conference
- Calls transition between the keynote speaker, guest speaker, and participants

Guest Speaker

- Speakers for different sessions of the event
- Talk on relatively contemporary topics
- More specific content and interactive session

Keynote Address at Conference

- ❑ Keynote address is the **defining presentation** of a conference which bears the important purpose to literally set the “key note” of the event.
- ❑ They are usually timed at the beginning as well as at the end of the event:
- ❑ **Opening Keynote:**
 - The talk sets a positive tone and tenor of conference by discussing on the principal issue/topic of the event.
 - The keynote speaker is usually a person of high reputation, knowledge, expertise and a compelling presentation style, and therefore, plays the role of a strong drawcard to attract and engage audience for the upcoming sessions.
- ❑ **Closing Keynote:**
 - The address ends the conference on a positive, optimistic and fruitful note.
 - An engaging topic is chosen to help retain the attendees until the end of the event.
 - Outlines the takeaway message of the event and adds to its reminiscence value.

Roles and Responsibilities – The Convener

- ❑ The convener of the conference assumes responsibility as the absolute chairperson for the entire duration (multiple days) of the conference. The convener:

Comes up with the idea of conducting the event – exhibits collaborative leadership

Assigns personnels the responsibilities of being the chairperson, coordinators, etc.

Presides over the team responsible for reviewing the abstracts of the presenters

Caps the opening and the ending of the program – delivers **Introductory Speech** and **Valedictory Address**

Defines the theme and the aim of the conference

Supervises the plan and proceedings of all the sessions

Ensures that the shortlisted abstracts are well-aligned within the theme of the event

Serves as a public face – **the media spokesperson** – for the event

Roles and Responsibilities: The Chairperson

Chairing the Sessions: The chair is responsible for the smooth conduction of his/her session, with the aid of the session coordinator. The responsibilities of the chair of a session are:

Inaugurate the Session

- Declare the session as 'open' officially
- Deliver an introductory talk on the theme to set the session in motion



Supervise the Session

- Oversee to ensure the apt conduct of the speakers, the audience and the moderator
- Listen attentively to each speaker's talk
- Ask questions and give feedback



Conclude the Session

- Recap the main message of each presenter's talk
- Outline the understanding and the takeaways of the session
- Formally announce the conclusion of the session

Roles and Responsibilities: The Session Coordinator

The tasks of the session coordinator of a conference can be enumerated as follows:

i. **Before the Commencement:**

- Collect the details about your session and the speakers.
- Contact the speakers and communicate with them the duration allotted for their talk.
- Get aware of speakers' need of any special equipment (for e.g., a sound or video clip) to facilitate his/her talk.
- Check the functionality of equipments and ensure the presence of speakers 15 minutes before the session starts.

ii. **Open the Session**

- Begin with a cordial welcome note.
- Announce the road-map, the format, and the rules of the session.
- Introduce the session and outline its theme.

Roles and Responsibilities: The Session Coordinator (Contd.)

iii. Run the Session

- Introduce the speakers, their topic of presentation and the time allotted for the talk.
- Ensure that speakers begin and end their talk within the specified time duration.
- See to it that the session sticks to its schedule.
- Run the Question-Answer session, select relevant and interesting questions for the speakers to answer.
- Remember to applaud each speaker after his/her talk.
- Encourage discussion and feedback at the end of the session.

iv. Wind up the Session

- Request attendees to fill up the feedback form towards the end of the session.
- Make concluding remarks; applaud and thank the audience and the speakers.

Roles and Responsibilities – The Rapporteur

A rapporteur is appointed to prepare a report summarizing the proceedings, resolutions, and outcome of the conference. S/He is required to:

- ☐ Grab a seat which begets minimal disruptions
- ☐ Listen attentively and take prompt notes
- ☐ Concentrate on – the key issues raised, main findings, remarks and feedback – in each presentation
- ☐ Record audio and capture photographs of vital informations
- ☐ Collect document detailing the participant list with titles of their presentation
- ☐ Avail yourself of all the handouts and other takeaways
- ☐ Get to work immediately post the event to minimize memory fade away
- ☐ Ensure that the report is comprehensive and well-edited

Requisite Skill Sets

Effective Listening Skill

Literary Skill

Editing Skill

Analytical Skill

Organizational Skill

Organizing a Conference: Pre-Conference Tasks

- Start **planning well ahead of time** – at least six months before the actual date of event.
- Decide a **suitable date** for the conference – one which would be preferred by most of prospective guests.
- Choose the **conference venue** – take into consideration factors like cost, accessibility of location and the available technical facilities.
- Formulate the **conference theme, title, format** and the sub-topics for discussion.
- Draw a **detailed schedule** of the event – with regard to the number of days, number of sessions per day and number of presenters per session.
- Design a **conference brochure** with all these information and communicate it with the participants and the guests through e-mail.

Organizing a Conference: Pre-Conference Tasks (Contd.)

- Identify and invite **guest speakers**, keynote speaker, plenary speaker, chairpersons and session coordinators and confirm their availability for the event.
- Release '**Call for Papers**' and constitute a team for reviewing and shortlisting the abstracts received.
- Make **arrangements for lodging** of the invited guests; **menu** and timing for different meals and refreshments; seating arrangements; **technological and audio-visual aids**.
- Constitute a **task force** and assign roles and responsibilities – reception and hospitality of guests, rapporteuring, technical assistance, advertising the event and overall management.
- Generate a **financial estimate** of organizing the event; enlist and **approach prospective sponsors**.
- **Create a buzz** about the event by **advertising it** on various social media platforms.

Organizing a Conference: The Conference Day/s

Cordially **receive and welcome** the guests and the speakers

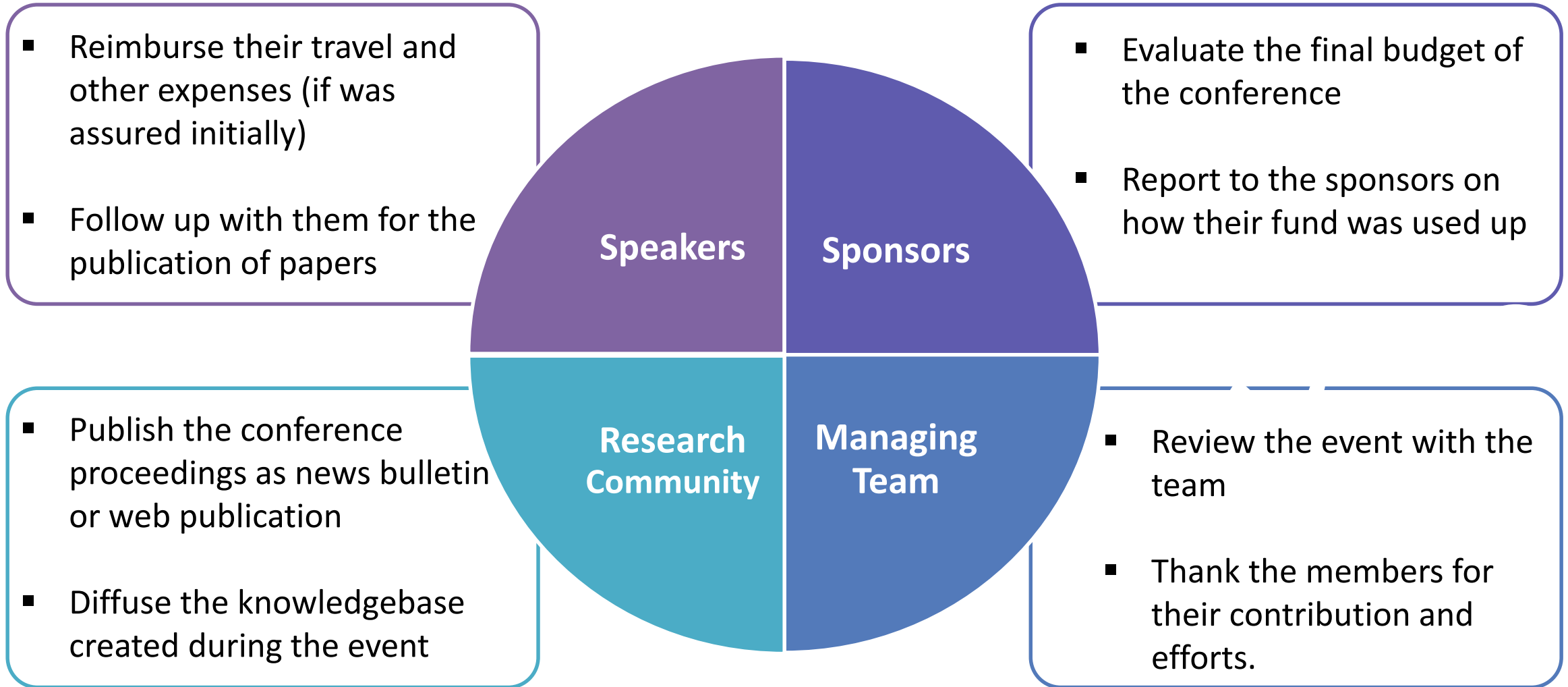
Distribute **conference pack** to all the attendees

Conference pack should include – the program schedule, list of participants with their mail ids, a brief city-guide, a list of useful contact numbers, a few white papers and a pen

Ensure your presence at as many lectures and events as possible

Make yourself available to **solve inconveniences** and to **offer assistance** wherever required

Organizing a Conference: Post-Conference Tasks



Organizing a Conference: A Sample Schedule

Inaugural Session – 90 Minutes

Welcome Address – 05 minutes

Introduction of the Conference's
Theme by the Convener – 05
minutes

Address by the Guest of Honour –
20 minutes

Address by the Chief Guest – 20
minutes

Keynote Address – 30 minutes

Concluding Remarks & Vote of
Thanks – 15 minutes

Multiple Parallel
Presentation Sessions
– around 120 minutes
each

With discrete Themes,
Chairpersons, Session-
Coordinators &
Rapporteurs

Valedictory Session – 60 Minutes

Presentation of the Conference
Report by the Convener – 15
minutes

Valedictory Address by the
Convener – 30 minutes

Concluding Remarks – 10 minutes

Vote of Thanks – 05 minutes

"A conference is like a vacation for your business. You're able to get away from the daily grind."

- Kristy Oustalet

Thank You!

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